



Portable music timeline

An infographic of the miniaturisation of portable music across the decades, with details on the gadgets. <https://digit.in/aug20-41>



History of the iPod

After the Walkman, the iPod was the most popular portable music device, here is its complete history. <https://digit.in/aug20-42>

turntables and microphones to be used along. The boombox was embraced by the younger generation due to its array of features and it became closely linked to American hip hop culture. However, the large size of the boomboxes proved to be a deterrent in mass adoption.

THE SONY WALKMAN

Possibly the most recognisable and nostalgia-inducing innovation in the history of portable music is Sony's Walkman. It was in the year 1979 when Sony released the very first self-contained, truly portable music system – the TPS-L2 Walkman cassette player. The highly-portable device measured only slightly larger than the cassette tape itself and weighed about 396 grams. Featuring the classic chunky buttons and not one, but two headphone jacks (so that two people could listen to music at the same time), the introduction of the Walkman pretty much transmogrified the landscape of portable music listening. The compact listening device also shipped with its own set of headphones and a couple of AA batteries. The device allowed users the freedom of choice since they could play music from their own selection of cassettes or even make their own!

The Walkman eventually went on to sell millions of units and even spawned multiple iterations for many years after its initial release. The device also got an unexpected boost in popularity in 2014 when it was featured in the Marvel film, *Guardians of the Galaxy*. Sony capitalised on this craze and released a new Walkman edition in honour of the film and the *Guardians of the Galaxy Awesome Mix Vol. 1* was released on cassette as well.

THE SONY DISCMAN

Years later, when CD sales began overtaking cassette sales, Sony recognised the need to update their portable music player solution. Sony introduced the D-50 portable CD player in 1984. The first iteration

was slightly bulky since it required a separate battery pack. However, the updated model, the D-20 Discman, introduced a built-in battery. The portable CD music player soon became mainstream and took over the portable music industry for the coming years. In 1997, the company changed the name of the device to CD Walkman to match the cassette Walkman branding.

THE FIRST MP3 PLAYERS

Ushering the portable music space into the digital age, MP3 players showed up to the scene in the late 90s. In 1997, South Korean company, SaeHan Information Systems released the MPMan F10, the first mass-produced portable solid state digital audio player, in other words, the first MP3 player. The device hit the US market in 1998. The MPMan featured 32MB of flash storage and could import songs from a PC. The device capable of storing 8 songs and featured an LCD display that showed the name of the song you were listening to. The device ran on a rechargeable NiMH battery pack and sported about 9 hours of battery life, which is actually better than many hard drive based music players today! However, it was extremely expensive and was said to be a commercial failure.

The first successful portable MP3 player was the Rio PMP300, which actually debuted just a few months after

the MPMan. The device was cheaper, could be connected to a PC easily, and was an overall better-received product. MP3 music players grew pretty popular over the next few years since they removed the need for physical media and mainly relied on digital files which was much more convenient. The format made its phone debut on Samsung's SPH-M100 model in 2000.



The original 1979 Sony Walkman TPS-L2



The 1st Generation iPod

THE IPOD

Leave it to Apple to sit back, relax, observe and then make a strong appearance in a particular field. Apple did just this before finally entering the MP3 music player market in 2001 with the release of the original iPod. The iPod overturned the landscape of portable music players completely, just as the Walkman did

back in 1979. Users could now load up not tens, not hundreds, but thousands of songs in a single, portable MP3 player, marketed by Steve Jobs memorably as a "1000 songs in your pocket". The device had a 5GB hard drive with a rechargeable battery pack. It also came with a slick UI and extremely premium-looking hardware. Although it only worked on Macintosh computers in the beginning, Apple soon realised that Windows support would be advantageous, and then iPods began reaching a much wider audience base.

The launch of iTunes in 2003 also meant that users could manage and update their music library easily, and could create new playlists in just a few clicks. As of December 2019, Apple has sold roughly 400 million units worldwide and the 7th generation iPod Touch is still available today.

SMARTPHONES

Although iPods blew all the other formats of portable music players out of the water in 2001, the introduction of the iPhone in 2008 sort of rendered the iPod useless, since the iPhone could play MP3 files and do SO much more.

Now, in 2020, smartphones are not only capable of playing MP3 files but also streaming music from multiple platforms such as Spotify, YouTube Music, and more. While we have reached heights of portability with the current day smartphone as a music player, older variants of music players still have their charm, which is why buying iPods, MP3 players and even cassette tape recorders has still not gone out of style. 